The butterfly cowboy

By James Holden

“Oro! Oro! Oro! Oro!” cry the women from the tiny village of Voivoro. My companions and I exchange uneasy looks, uncertain of the protocol or even the friendliness of this greeting. The women approach, continuing their unnerving chant. But when they get within arm’s reach they become silent, offering soft handshakes and bowing their heads slightly. The eleven of us form an impromptu reception line as the men of Voivoro now welcome us with their own gentle hands. The final man to greet us stands out from the rest of the villagers dressed in their ragbag hand-me-downs. He appears quintessentially Western and middle-aged in a crisp, pale blue shirt, light grey slacks and black slip-on shoes.

He shakes our hands firmly, looking us in the eyes. His jaw-line is round and strong and slightly shiny from a recent shave. He has a bulging brow-line overarching wide-set eyes and a short, broad nose. He beams at each of us benevolently, showing straight white teeth.

This is Russell Hauro, washed, clean-shaven, dressed up and ready to go to town.

A dozen timber-framed huts with palm-woven walls and grass-thatched roofs – Voivoro is a seemingly unremarkable village of around 40 people. The hamlet is about an hour’s drive along rough dirt roads from Popondetta, the capital of the Northern Province of Papua New Guinea.

It’s not a particularly difficult journey in a four-wheel-drive as long as you know where you’re going. There are no signs and after a while the oil palm groves that march away from the roadways in cathedralesque columns tend to meld into one. The final turnoff is a narrow track nearly overwhelmed by head-high Sudan grass. Take a detour through the settlement of Ondahari to avoid the log blocking the track, drop down into a gully, across a rickety drive-of-faith bridge, up a short rise and you’re there. When you arrive expect to be greeted by the ladies of Voivoro, who will call out ‘Oro! Oro! Oro!” to you – “Welcome! Welcome! Welcome!”

For a physically- and emotionally-draining eight days we have been immersed in PNG culture, Australian wartime history and most of all sweat. Yesterday we were a couple of hour's drive west of here – we were at Kokoda Station drinking SP beer and telling improbable stories about our adventure on the infamous track of the same name.

But today we have come to Voivoro to see Russell Hauro's butterflies.

PNG village life is almost entirely dependent on local resources available, so Russell Hauro – as village chief and head of the community council – decided to make use of Voivoro's greatest natural asset, Queen Alexandra's birdwing, arguably the world's rarest butterfly. Unlike other species, which are seen throughout PNG, Queen Alexandra's birdwing is only found in three small populations, one of which is on the plains near Popondetta. If that's not enough to attract butterfly enthusiasts, it is also the world's biggest – adult females have wingspans up to 300 mm. That's slightly larger than an average-sized dinner plate.

What the male lacks in size he makes up for in colour. With his aqua-green and cobalt blue markings, he is a queen in name and nature. His patterns radiate out from a fat yellow, Cuban-cigar-abdomen in feathery brush strokes that contrast vividly with a black background canvas. The female is big and drab brown with the odd splash of yellow. Compared to Mr Mardi Gras the poor love looks like she needs a good spruce up.

Although he is officially retired, Dr Don Sands is still fired by butterfly passion. So he comes into work at the CSIRO (Commonwealth Scientific and Industrial Research Organisation) laboratories in Brisbane a couple of days a week, even though his salary has long ceased.

Don is a stoutish, shortish man with a full head of grey hair and together we squeeze into his three-metre square office. The cubicle is packed with a lifetime's research – papers and loose-bound documents cover most of the benches. As Don is telling me the recent history of the Queen Alexandra's birdwing butterfly in PNG he frequently jumps up, pulling down thick textbooks from overloaded shelves to prove a point or to show me how to spell a taxonomic name. There is a faint smell of mothballs emanating from one

corner. There, about half a dozen wooden boxes are stacked. They contain pinned butterflies, caterpillars and chrysalises preserved with crystals of naphthalene.

In a measured tone that reminds me of Barry Humphries delivering a well-considered monologue, Don tells me of a Belgian called Ray Straatman who, starting in the 1950s, worked for the Australian government in PNG for two decades.

“Ray was a brilliant biologist,” Don says with evident admiration. “He discovered the life cycles of many of the Papuan birdwings, including *alexandrae*,” he continues, using the second part of the butterfly’s scientific name.

“He took on-board several Papua New Guinean young lads to collect butterflies for him.

“Ray was probably gay,” he says matter-of-factly “although we never really found out,” he qualifies.

He adds that Ray was a partisan in the Second World War – his speciality was blowing up German trains. After the war, Ray immigrated to Australia and joined CSIRO.

Don says Russell Hauro was one of Ray Straatman’s students. From Ray, the young Russell learnt how to breed, catch, prepare and pin birdwing butterflies. But Russell discovered the value of Queen Alexandra’s specimens for himself.

“In the early 1960s a large number of collectors were working out of PNG – many of them Japanese – hiring locals to hunt birdwings.”

Collectors were offering Papuans between one and two hundred dollars for a pair in good condition. These would be sold on as cased specimens for between two and five thousand dollars, depending on the quality and size of the butterflies.

“The villagers were so good at spotting them, collecting started to threaten some of the species – it just couldn’t continue.”

So Australian laws, later superceded by PNG laws, were passed in 1968 that protected all but two common birdwing butterfly species in PNG. It became illegal to farm, collect or trade in birdwings without a permit. And permits were not issued for Queen Alexandra's.

But illicit trade in the rare butterfly continued throughout the 1970s.

"Boxfuls of unset (unpinned) specimens were still being bought by Japenese collectors. And we all know where most of them came from," Don says with a conspiratorial grin.

In the 1980s the International Union for Conservation of Nature and Natural Resources (IUCN) passed an international law, categorising many of the birdwings from PNG as protected. Queen Alexandra's was becoming so rare it was classed as endangered – all international trade was strictly forbidden.

Some twenty years later in May 2000, Russell found himself taking the first plane journey of his life courtesy of the Canadian government. At the Vancouver Provincial Court, Gilles Deslisle, a French Canadian from Quebec, was being tried for importing Queen Alexandra's birdwing butterfly specimens. Russell was the star witness for the prosecution. He alleged that Deslisle acquired six specimens from PNG between 1996 and 1999. This was not second hand information or rumour – Russell was well acquainted with the facts because he was the person who supplied Deslisle with the butterflies. He received between $350 and $500 for each specimen – on the black market they are worth up to $30,000.

Russell was portrayed as "an exceedingly unsophisticated individual" who was bribed by the self-taught amateur entomologist Deslisle to collect the specimens. Russell did nothing to dispel this bucolic image when he needed help to use hotel lifts.

Although the appeals court judge found Deslisle's motives were "ego satisfaction, rather than monetary gain", she upheld the original decision to fine the Canadian $80,000.

After the initial court case, Russell returned to Voivoro, where he was given a hero's welcome. He was now a local celebrity – no one from the village had travelled out of the Northern Province, let alone to another country.

In January 2001 Russell was granted full immunity from prosecution for conspiring to export an endangered species. The decision had been based on advice from lawyers involved in the Canadian court case. It was as if Russell was seen as a victim rather than a fellow perpetrator.

According to Dr Don Sands the incident, and the years of black-market trading in Queen Alexandra's that preceded it, would not have occurred if his suggested plan had been implemented.

In 1996 the Australian Agency for International Development (AusAid) funded a study of Queen Alexandra's birdwing in PNG. The seven million dollar project was conducted by AACM – a South Australian company specialising in natural resource management. The principle researcher, Christopher Mercer, reviewed all the research, completed intensive monitoring, and then suggested ways of conserving the butterfly.

Don Sands was the consultant entomologist for the four-year study.

Don does not criticise the project's methodology. But he feels locals such as Russell – although he took part in a vine-planting program to increase the density of the caterpillar's food source – should have been more involved.

"Russell knew lots of snippets of information that no one else was aware of – for instance he knew that *alexandrae* chose some food-vine plants over others."

He is also less than impressed with Mercer's suggestions for conservation, which, he says do little to encourage locals to look after the species.

Don says the critical thing about Queen Alexandra's birdwing is its enormous size. The larger the specimen, the more it is worth.

"In the wild you get a range of sizes. But I had developed, through my work with the Richmond birdwing butterfly here in Australia, a method of making adults very big. It's related to nutrition in the caterpillar stage."

Don proposed – under government supervision and through a strictly controlled breeding program – that a small number of Queen Alexandra's should be released onto the world market each year, effectively putting an end to black-market trade.

Only the largest and most valuable specimens would be sold, the rest would be released into the wild, supplementing the natural population. The income from the sale of the butterflies would be distributed to the villages on a proportional basis, depending on how much they were doing to conserve Queen Alexandra's birdwing.

"It was foolproof. CSIRO approved it; the project's lawyer approved it, but AACM didn't want to know, so it fell flat," Don says, clearly disappointed even four years after his recommendation was rejected.

Russell was also disillusioned with the project's outcomes.

Hoping to attract overseas visitors to the village, he built a guesthouse at the start of the AusAid study. It was a bold move that he says cost him in excess of than $10,000 – more than a lifetime's earnings in Papua New Guinea. It even rated a mention in the 1998 edition of the Lonely Planet guide for PNG, which said, "(the ecotourism lodge) is a chance to support the income-earning efforts of rural people." But shortly after this Lonely Planet withdrew their PNG guide from publication because of safety concerns for tourists.

About the same time the AusAid project was finalised and the income Russell and the villagers were getting for monitoring Queen Alexandra's birdwing disappeared.

For two years Russell struggled on with his ecotourism lodge and butterfly sanctuary. But the tiny trickle of visitors all but dried up.

Eventually Russell became so angry and frustrated he invited officials from the provincial government, local conservation groups and the oil palm industry to Voivoro. Dr Paul Nelson, an ex-pat Australian and the agricultural research manager for the Oil Palm Research Association, was there.

“When we arrived at the village, there was a woven-palm barricade blocking the entrance,” Paul recalls.

He says as the group approached the wall they heard a voice call out.

“Are you the father and mother of the environment?” it challenged.

“No one knew what to say, so we just stood there in silence.”

The voice called out again, with more force, “Are you the father and mother of the environment?” Silence again.

“It was getting embarrassing by this stage, but finally someone replied ‘Yes!’”

But Paul says the inquisition wasn’t over. “Have you come here to help or just to look?” the voice demanded.

“Thankfully someone answered almost immediately this time, saying we were there to help and the barricade was opened.”

There was Russell, ready to challenge his guests in ceremonial dress, including a magnificent headpiece made from the resplendent feathers of the bird of paradise.

“He danced towards us and thrust a spear into the ground near our feet. Then he pulled it out, retreated a few steps and stabbed the ground again.

“Finally he let us into the village, and we sat down and had a sing-sing and a feast as if we were all best mates,” Paul remembers with a smile.

Russell had made his point. And nothing changed.

But Russell did have one small win. Ever the supreme opportunist, as the official party left he asked them to take his lawnmower into Popondetta for repairs.

Today Paul Nelson is back at Voivoro. He has brought us to visit Russell Hauro and hopefully to see his butterflies. Russell tells Paul he wants to charge the group 20 kina (about 10 dollars). This will include entry into the village for the group and a guided walk through the rainforest that surrounds the village. At less than a dollar each, the price seems extraordinarily cheap. But Russell plays his first opportunist card of the day – he says if we want to take a photo of a Queen Alexandra's birdwing butterfly, each picture will cost 50 kina, including those of a caterpillar or chrysalis.

When Paul conveys this information to the group a brief discussion ensues. We decide 25 dollars split eleven ways is a mere pittance for this photo opportunity. And we nominate Ingrid, an athletic Australian of Danish extract, as our official photographer. This is partly because she has the best camera – which she lugged in its heavy plastic case for the length of the Kokoda Track – and partly because she seems to know how to use it. These are pertinent points because the group has decided she is only going to get one shot at it.

Russell's son David will be our guide. He is a quiet man in his early 20s of average height and build for a Papuan, which is about 170 cm tall and nearly the same around the chest. He leads the way out of the village along a well-used path. In single file we follow his broad frame into a tunnel of dense undergrowth.

David is dressed ready for a visit to Popondetta with his father, except he is wearing his purple and gold Bronco's rugby league shirt inside out. David says he wants to keep it clean. When he gets to town, he'll turn it the right way round.

After a few minutes the path reaches a shallow river with sunlight dappling the gently-flowing current. We wade through the stream, not bothering to remove our sandals.

As we climb the slippery bank on the other side, Greg Shannon, a typically laconic Australian, turns to me and says, "I thought we'd finished with this shit."

After another five minutes David pauses, perhaps for effect, and he looks up into the canopy. He points out the climbing vine that is the staple diet of the birdwing's caterpillar

stage and grows thick and lush on the phosphorus-rich volcanic soils of the Popondetta Plains.

Don Sands believes vine nutrition is what limits the butterfly to this area. And he says the rapid growth of the oil palm industry has destroyed much of the butterfly's habitat, driving it towards extinction.

We all stop and look upwards hoping to see an iridescently-coloured dinner plate flutter into view. David crosses the track and grabs a hand-sized leaf. He flips it over exposing pale green varicose-like veins. The group gathers around.

A yellow and brown scaly lump is attached to the partly-chewed leaf by its spiny bottom and a stiletto-thin spike.

We have found the Queen Alexandra's birdwing butterfly. If we came back in a few days we could watch this three-inch long pupa break open. If we were patient and watched for three more days we could see it slowly unfold its ruler-wide wings. We could witness the metamorphosis of what is perhaps the most rare, most spectacular, and undeniably the largest butterfly on the planet.

As it is, we have to make do with a yellow and brown protuberance that sits motionless on a vine leaf.

But the indefatigable Ingrid is not disheartened. She brings the camera up to her face and prepares to record the event – or rather, the lack of one. But at the last minute she pauses, then passes the camera to Paul, saying, "I think I'll hold the leaf."

In other words, "You're the one responsible for us being here, you can be the one to waste $25 on a picture of a lump on a leaf." Fair call, I'd say.

Paul shrugs and takes the camera; Ingrid takes the leaf. One more helper is required – at least their shoulder is required – to act as a human tripod. I can't resist taking a photo of the photographer and his assistants. David glances at me after my flash goes off – I hope

I’m not going to be charged $25 for taking a photo of someone taking a photo of a lump on leaf.

The irony is,” Paul says as he completes his shot, “Queen Alexandra’s are mostly seen in people’s gardens.”

Greg gives me another laconic look and we head back to Voivoro.

But Russell is not finished with us. At the village he approaches Paul holding the money he gave him when we arrived. Together they walk to the corner of the communal hut – a palm-thatched pagoda with a raised floor.

“Here is your 20 kina,” Russell says showing the grubby note to Paul. “Now you owe 130 kina.”

When Paul questions this Russell says, “Yes, 20 kina to come to the village, 50 kina for the photo and 80 kina to leave.”

Paul quickly realises the futility of arguing and hands Russell the outstanding money.

“By the way,” Paul says as we walk back to the vehicles, “we’re also giving Russell and David a lift into Popondetta.”

Depending on the occasion Russell Hauro has several hats that he likes to wear – village chief, local hero, businessman, conservationist and erstwhile star witness in a Canadian court.

But his favourite is undoubtedly his town hat, which he is wearing now as he sits in the backseat of Paul’s dual cab utility. It’s a black Stetson, which has emblazoned across the brow in bold white letters – COWBOY.

Word count 3119